Chatar stiffened. Perhaps he knew he had underestimated Mathur's spycraft and realised that peddling propaganda through him would not be easy. He immediately guided Mathur and Sartaj out of his house. The fresh air cleared Mathur's head and before opening the door of his car, he handed Chatar his direct telephone number in case he 'would like to meet again sometime'.

'I will think about it/ Chatar said rudely.

They shook hands. 'I look forward to seeing you again/ were Mathur's last words before Sartaj switched on the ignition.

Back in his office, Mathur drafted a memo about his meeting with Chatar and kept it under lock and key. He had no technical intelligence support; the spy operation deep inside the USA was purely dependent on informers.

'Chatar would have been a trophy if only I was able to command him as I wished/ recalled Mathur about the days he spent thinking about the unusual meeting. 'I had a gut feeling he was well positioned to provide information on militants crisscrossing western countries to foment trouble in Punjab. I told Sartaj that if we could learn his weaknesses, it would be easy to lure him into working for the R&AW.'

By early December, Sartaj had produced a dossier on Chatar, with details of his family and business interests in the USA. Although there was no mention of his private life, the dossier noted that he was reckless and highly radicalised. Mathur recognised that any effort to make a dent in Chatar's loyalty to pro-Khalistan outfits would require psychological pressure as well as dollar bills. Chatar had not called Mathur even once since that strange meeting. It was a clear message that Chatar